

BAROQUE AND ROCOCO

Opulence, grandeur, heavy ornamentation, and rich colours were the defining characteristics of fashion throughout Europe in the 17th century. No one demonstrated this baroque style to greater effect than King Carl Gustav of Sweden, who wore such a richly decorated doublet at his coronation in 1654 that the fabric beneath the embroidery was completely invisible. The baroque style was set at the royal court in France, where the stiff-bodied, heavy-skirted court dress known as the *grand habit* was established in the splendour of Louis XIV's Versailles. The fabrics for these stately clothes were produced across Europe, but the French silk industry, centred in Lyon, dominated. Further afield, the influx of goods from Asia via trading organizations such as the Dutch East India Company, founded in 1602, meant that printed cottons and painted silks from India and China flooded the European fashion market.

Rococo lightness

By the 18th century there was a move in the decorative arts towards a lighter, more flowing aesthetic known as the rococo, which was reflected in fashion. This could be seen in the curving lines of the silk designs produced by such craftspeople as Anna Maria Garthwaite and the Spitalfields silk weavers in London, many of them Protestant Huguenots who had fled religious persecution in France. Gone was the boned bodice and skirt, to be replaced first by a loose, full-skirted gown known as a mantua, and then by an open robe and petticoat. Men's doublet and hose had disappeared too, giving way to coat and breeches.

Revolutionary spirit

By about the 1770s England was setting the principal style in men's dress with the coat called the frock, worn by men for countryside pursuits. This more informal look was taken up in revolutionary America and even in France, the centre of fashion, where the revolutionary leaders opted for styles that set them apart from the aristocratic and increasingly isolated Ancien Régime. It was around this time, too, that cottons and muslins traded from the East became the new wonder fabrics, and women's dress took on a softer silhouette.

FASHION EXTREMES

Young fops of the 1770s, nicknamed "macaronis", took fashion to absurd heights, wearing extravagant clothes and towering wigs.



1625–40	1641–70	1671–80	
 ▲ Henrietta Maria, French wife of Charles I of England	1649 The English Commonwealth is proclaimed, with puritanical Oliver Cromwell at its head. Style in England becomes more subdued as a result. ► Oliver Cromwell	 ▼ Louis XIV, the Sun King	
	1660 Charles II is proclaimed King of England, and a year later Louis XIV assumes personal rule of France – the monarchy is re-established as the centre of European fashion.		
1625 Charles I ascends the throne and marries Henrietta Maria of France; she brings the fashions of the French court with her. Meanwhile, black clothes remain popular in the Dutch United Provinces (now the Netherlands).	1666 Charles II introduces the Persian vest and the justaucorps (a style of long coat) to England.		
1630s The "bucket-top" boot for men makes an appearance, and strings of pearls become fashionable for women.	 ► Bucket-top boots and abundant lace	1670s Louis XIV, to disguise his growing baldness, promotes the fashion of wearing wigs.	
		1675 Under sumptuary laws protecting local markets, Charles II bans the import of French lace into England.	